

CoARA Action Plan

I. Introduction

The Hungarian Academy of Sciences (Magyar Tudományos Akadémia, MTA) is the oldest science-funding organization in the country with a reputation based on a nearly 200-year-long experience and acts as the most prominent member of the Hungarian scientific ecosystem. The MTA represents all-Hungarian science, integrating and coordinating both the applicants for its funds and the scientific reviewers living within and across the borders of the country, and ensures links within the nation and with the international scientific community as well. The MTA advocates scientific views and is a major representative of the interests of the research community in Hungary, as stated in the [“Mission of the Hungarian Academy of Sciences”](#). Acting independently from the government and unbiased in terms of political views, MTA relies on the guarantees provided by its governance and decision-making structure, as well as by the regulatory background applying to its activities as a public body. Stabilized by long-lasting norms MTA is, however flexible in reacting to new challenges imposed either by recent issues requesting scientific replies or by changes in the national and international operational framework, and adapts to the regulatory environment without compromising the independence of science.

The Academy works as a science-funding organization and as a traditional learned society. Among its public duties the MTA

- supports the cultivation of sciences and the conduct of scientific research, promotes the publication of scientific books and journals;
- operates a scientific qualification system, within the framework of which it awards the title of Doctor of the Hungarian Academy of Sciences (the “Doctor of the Academy”), and the title of corresponding and full member of the Hungarian Academy of Sciences, and, upon request, evaluates institutions pursuing scientific activities. The rules of awarding titles and evaluations are listed by the Academy in regulations;

- assists young scientists by maintaining a scholarship system, the funding of which is provided separately in the budget of the Academy; it may establish scientific scholarships, awards, award prizes for a definite period of time for researchers achieving outstanding scientific results – from its own resources or based on a joint commitment in the public interest – the conditions and the detailed rules of which are established in the regulations of the Academy;
- operates together with the Library and Information Centre of the Hungarian Academy of Sciences the Hungarian Scientific Bibliography Database (MTMT), a national Current Research Information System (CRIS), established with the aim to record and guide someone to the content of the scientific research results in Hungary, and in the light of these duties it aims at fulfilling the CoARA commitments.

The Hungarian Academy of Sciences has been a member of the Coalition for Advancing Research Assessment since December 2022.

The action plan of the Hungarian Academy of Sciences aims to summarize existing practices in line with the CoARA commitments, set out further actions and define milestones for the undertakings.

II. Starting points

- The strategy of the MTA towards the reform of research assessment stems in the Mission of the Hungarian Academy of Sciences referred above. Observes the latest trends of science policy and applies international achievements in order to offer standards to be followed by the entire Hungarian scientific community. It is not however a body to operate with regulations applicable to all actors of the community, it is successful in leading by example. The above values are reflected in the rules of its programmes of excellence. In line with the mission, it monitors the availability of publication channels for researchers and takes every measure to ensure proper publication opportunities. As the custodian of scientific excellence and the ethical conduct of science, it operates a national scheme to ensure the compliance of Hungarian science with international standards of scientific integrity. In the process of awarding the academic title “Doctor of the Academy” and via the excellence programmes it offers a system of quality assurance governed by uniform rules in compliance with international requirements, and is maintained by highly qualified experts.

In promoting the distribution of scientific results and the latest achievements in science policy, it observes the achievements of the reform of research assessment. As one of its public duties stipulated by law it operates together with the Library and Information Centre of the Hungarian Academy of Sciences the Hungarian Science Bibliography (MTMT).

- The MTA is member of several international science organizations (SE, EASAC, CEUS, ALLEA, AE, ISC, SAPEA, YAE, GYA) and signatory - directly or by its members – of declarations and agreements targeting the reform of research assessment (DORA, OS, CoARA), and applies the principles in awarding titles, and in its scientific excellence programs and institute evaluations.
- The Hungarian Academy of Sciences in partnership with UNESCO, ICSU and AAAS established World Science Forum, a series of follow-up events, taking place every four years in Budapest, a meeting to foster and maintain a dialogue between the scientific community, society, policy-makers, and industry, a Forum to emphasize the significance, relevance, and responsibilities of science on a global scale.
- In the course of the planned reforms, the MTA is holding a mirror to continuously work on improving and renewing the assessment practices used in line with the CoARA commitments. The preparation of calls for application include review processes for the implementation of actions that aim to observe the CoARA goals.
- As a learned society, the Hungarian Academy of Sciences is the main national body for the representation of science in Hungary and abroad. The association of the Academy extends beyond its ordinary, corresponding, honorary and external membership and incorporates over 18000 scientists with a PhD degree from all domains and sectors of science, with whom there is a constant interaction. The MTA will use its regular channels to communicate with the members about the reform of evaluation practices, similarly it also pays attention to the expectations of political decision-makers when designing the reform goals. This ensures that the MTA's actions will reflect the requirements of the key stakeholders of the Hungarian scientific ecosystem.
- Communication of good practices along with scientific results and science popularization are also in the core of the activities of the Academy. Organisation

of hundreds of workshops, conferences, the one-month-long Hungarian Science festival, various events and meetings of the scientific sections are only a few of the programs that help disseminate and discuss good practices in the field of the reform of research assessment. Year 2025 falls in the implementation period of the COARA commitments, the year which marks the 200th anniversary of the Hungarian Academy of Sciences, and nationwide it will be the dedicated year of science.

III. CoARA core commitments and MTA actions

1. Recognise the diversity of contributions to, and careers in research, in accordance with the needs and nature of the research

Implemented:

- The National Science Bibliography (MTMT), the national CRIS system, managed as a public duty by the Library and Information Centre of the Hungarian Academy of Sciences is used for various evaluation purposes, which already contains diverse research outputs or creator roles.
- MTMT already provides means for authors to present their selected, most important papers.
- The system is constantly developed to reflect diverse scientific contributions of researchers.

Planned:

As a further development, a re-modelling of MTMT is planned in line with the CoARA commitments.

- The research outputs reflected in the system will be further expanded and elaborated according to CoARA goals.
- The system already provides means for authors to present their selected, most important papers. We will examine the possibility of requesting a minimum number of Open Access publications.
- Giving credit for peer review is a growing need in the scholarly community. We will develop a system to collect such credits from various sources and a way to display such credits in MTMT.
- MTMT already provides means for authors to present their selected, most important papers. This system could be expanded, e.g. contributor roles

could be indicated using existing taxonomies like CRediT. Presenting Open Access full texts in the selected list could also be improved.

2. Base research assessment primarily on qualitative evaluation for which peer review is central, supported by responsible use of quantitative indicators

Implemented:

Based on the expertise gained over the decades in the assessment of basic research applications, constant improvement of the complex process of research evaluation is a key objective. It requires consideration of a number of factors, it cannot be quantified and it needs to be based on expert wisdom.

- The MTA introduced research assessment based on qualitative indicators for a number of its grants and awards or in the process of evaluating institutions to recognize diversity of researchers' activity and research career.
- The MTA introduced the use of narrative CVs in case of its most prominent grant and selected awards.

Planned:

- The possibility of introducing narrative CVs for the purposes of further grant programmes, awards and titles will be assessed.
- Authors' personal profile in MTMT will be extended, including scholarly career elements.

3. Abandon inappropriate uses in research assessment of journal- and publication-based metrics, in particular inappropriate uses of Journal Impact Factor (JIF) and h-index

Implemented:

- Instead of publication-based indicators (IF, h-index) MTA panels assess publications declared to be the most relevant from the last five years.
- Projects of national relevance (Hungaricum-type) are assessed separately.
- In the case of evaluating institutions, exclusive use of publication-based metrics has been altered with a balanced use of quantitative and qualitative indicators both for evaluation of researchers and research institutions.

- The MTA published its recommendations on new types of publication misconduct and the report has been made available on the website, sent personally to policy makers, university rectors and heads of doctoral schools and has been digitally distributed to the 18,000 members of MTA's public body: <https://mta.hu/english/proposals-for-the-handling-of-articles-for-journals-that-engage-in-objectionable-practices-mtas-recommendations-on-new-types-of-publication-misconduct-113312>.

Planned:

- In the MTMT modern, domain-specific indicators will be developed for the complex, multi-factor characterisation of researchers, institutions and journals in different evaluation situations with the consent of key stakeholders.

4. Avoid the use of rankings of research organisations in research assessment

Implemented:

- In the assessment of funding a research project, ranking of the research organization hosting the project is not considered, only the suitability for the purposes of the project is examined.

5. Commit resources to reforming research assessment as is needed to achieve the organisational changes committed to

Implemented:

- Reforming research assessment already involves commitment and action from the leaders of the organization.

Planned:

- All segments of the MTA's organization involved in research assessment will dedicate resources with the objective of the reform.

6. Review and develop research assessment criteria, tools and processes – Criteria for researchers units and institutions

Implemented:

- In the assessment of institutions (MTA Centres of Excellence), each application cycle is followed by an evaluation of the assessment process and lessons learned are implemented in the next cycle.
- Raising awareness regarding science assessment is a constant goal. Therefore, funded researchers and panel members are asked for regular feedback to refine and improve calls for proposals and evaluation procedures.
- Calls for proposals are regularly updated taking into account suggestions from the reviewers during the evaluation process. The presentation of individual research results and their impact has been strengthened.
- Results of surveys regarding the situation of young researchers are published regularly by the Hungarian Young Academy. Regular feedback is provided to grant applicants on the content and formal requirements of calls for proposals, the decision-making process and the evaluation of proposals, or on the situation of young women and women researchers.
- Mentoring programme for the award of the János Bolyai Research Scholarship is provided by the Hungarian Young Academy.
- Research career monitoring is provided by the Library. The aim of the MTA Career Monitoring project is to evaluate the research support schemes of the MTA available for entry level and postdoctoral researchers (Lendület Program [Momentum Program], MTA Posztdoktori Kutatói Program [MTA Postdoctoral Research Program] and the Bolyai János Kutatási Ösztöndíj [János Bolyai Research Scholarship]), as well as the career and performance of researchers supported by these programs.

Planned:

- The review of the assessment criteria, tools and processes is repeated after each assessment cycle in order to improve assessment in line with the CoARA commitment.

7. Raise awareness of research assessment reform and provide transparent communication, guidance, and training on assessment criteria and processes as well as their use

Implemented:

- Information material is prepared and meetings are organized regularly to inform the experts and panel members regarding the evaluation process, experiences and refining the process.
- [The regulations of the project management](#), evaluation and funding process are available for the public, similar to the criteria and scoring scales.
- A multi-level evaluation and decision-making process ensures dominance of professional and scientific excellence-based criteria.
- Rules of conflict of interest are public and are observed.
- The MTA has a [mandate on the Open Access](#) to the publication of scientific works related to research activities carried out with the budget support available in the budget chapter of the Hungarian Academy of Sciences, as well as other public research support.

Planned:

- The Hungarian Young Academy, with the cooperation and support of MTA, will compile online training material on good publishing practices and ethical issues in scientific research, taking into account the characteristics of the discipline. On request, but at least once every six months, consultation opportunities regarding the material will be possible via webinar.

8. Exchange practices and experiences to enable mutual learning within and beyond the Coalition

Implemented:

- The MTA is member of the CoARA Hungarian National Chapter and takes part in the regular meetings. Participates at forums organised by the CoARA secretariat and forums of the Science Europe and the Global Research Council.

Planned:

- The active participation of the MTA in forums enabling exchange of practices and experiences to enable mutual learning will be sustained.

9. Communicate progress made on adherence to the Principles and implementation of the Commitments

Implemented:

- Communication of the progress made is ensured during hundreds of workshops and conferences organised by the Academy and the Library, the one-month-long Hungarian Science festival, various events and meetings of the scientific sections also help disseminate and discuss good practices in the field of the reform of research assessment.

Planned:

- The MTA will continue to communicate progress on the above mentioned channels.

10. Evaluate practices, criteria and tools based on solid evidence and the state-of-the-art in research on research, and make data openly available for evidence gathering and research

Implemented:

- The Hungarian Academy of Sciences has a long tradition in the science of science, quantitative science studies and, especially, evaluative scientometrics. A special department within the Library (the Department of Science Policy and Scientometrics), originating from a research unit founded by the Academy in the '80s, a pioneer in the field of scientometrics, fundamentally shaping its international development (Information Science and Scientometrics Research Unit), has long been dedicated to (1) research on scientometrics research evaluation and (2) translating and valorizing research results for informed and improved research evaluation practices.

Planned:

- Providing research and practical developments on adapting these methodologies for country-level and country-specific contexts via the valorization of domestic resources. In this respect, of priority is the due valorization of the MTMT in context-dependent and country-specific assessment, by developing and implementing valid measurement systems for various levels of aggregation (country, institution, researcher, journal, research field and other communities) based on its data and architecture.

IV. Roadmap of the research assessment reforms in line with the CoARA commitments

2023

- MTA joined CoARA and signed ARRA.

2024

- MTA joined the Hungarian National Chapter and engaged in co-leading the NCh together with HUN-REN.
- Representatives of MTA, the Secretariat of the MTA, Library and Information Centre of the MTA and members of the Hungarian Young Academy join 5 CoARA working groups.
- Carries out workshops with stakeholders to define details of the reform of the national Science Bibliography (MTMT).

2025-2026

- Continuous improvement of the national Science Bibliography (MTMT)

2026-2027

- Assessment of the possibility of introducing narrative CVs for the purposes of further grant programmes, awards and titles.
- The review of the researchers', research projects' and research units' assessment criteria, tools and processes is repeated after each assessment cycle in order to improve assessment in line with the CoARA commitment.
- Monitoring of the reform of the research assessment
- Active participation in national and international organizations, networks and working groups.
- Evaluation and assessment of further development goals.

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